BANGLADESH

BALLOT IN BANGLADESH

A SAYING DOING THE ROUNDS IN DHAKA captures the mood ahead of Bangladesh's February 12 general election: whatever is the result, the country's next prime minister will be a Rahman, a light-hearted reference to the leading contenders—Tarique Rahman of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) and Dr Shafiqur Rahman of the Jamaat-e-Islami (JeI). Beneath the humour lies a serious political moment. This will be the first national election since the dramatic fall of the Sheikh Hasina regime in 2024, and it brings together veterans, established ideological forces and a new generation shaped by street protests and reformist ambitions. Alongside the parliamentary polls, voters will also decide on a far-reaching constitutional charter of proposed electoral, administrative, judicial and educational reforms. For India, the election is equally significant, as New Delhi prepares to recalibrate its engagement with Dhaka in line with the priorities and diplomatic posture of Bangladesh's next political leadership.

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Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

WHAT'S NEW

- The general election on February 12 will elect members of the 13th Jatiya Sangsad (Parliament)
- Electoral reforms include reintroducing a 'no vote' option in constituencies with only one candidate, meant to improve democratic choice
- For the first time, expatriate Bangladeshi citizens can vote via postal ballots

THE JULY NATIONAL CHARTER REFERENDUM

Signed on October 17, 2025, it is a consensus political document signed by 30 parties aiming to usher in institutional reform. The referendum to the charter will be held parallel to the polls. It includes over 80 reform proposals. Key features:

- Formation of caretaker governments before polls and an independent Election Commission
- Transition into a bicameral parliament, with a 100-member upper house elected by proportional representation based on votes received in the election
- Obligation to implement reforms like increased women's representation, a two-term limit for the PM, judicial independence, a human rights commission and more

350

Number of seats in the Jatiya Sangsad; 300 directly elected from single-member constituencies, plus 50 reserved women's seats allocated to parties proportionately. A simple majority requires 151seats out of the 300 directly elected ones



128 MILLION

Total number of registered voters, the largest electorate in Bangladesh's history. Out of these, 64.8 million are men, while 62.8 million are women